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Watchdog closes case against candidate

CPS inspector: Allegations against school board hopeful Dominguez couldn't be corroborated

By Alice Yin and Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Chicago Public Schools watchdog did not substantiate misconduct allegations against a school board president candidate because they could not be corroborated and, even if proved true, did "not necessarily prove he acted for a sexual purpose," according to a copy of the office's report obtained by the Tribune.

In closing the case against Hilario Dominguez, CPS Inspector General Philip Wagenknecht's office wrote that the allegations that he behaved inappropriately toward a 17-year-old volunteer at a nonprofit where he worked nearly a decade ago lacked "electronic messages and eyewitness testimony," per a redacted copy of the findings obtained by the Tribune in a public records request.

The district sent letters informing both Dominguez and the woman of the inspector general's decision to close the case last week. But the redacted report gives the most details yet about the investigation.

"Based on (the woman's) account, there were no identified witnesses to either incident, and it would be extremely difficult to sufficiently corroborate two brief and unwitnessed interactions that occurred in 2017," the Office of the Inspector General wrote. "The passage of time has always been an issue in this case."

The report also says the inspector general found "there is insufficient evidence that — as alleged — Dominguez's one-time question to (her) about her dating preferences or his single instance of physically boundary-crossing contact constituted 'sexual advance(s)' or 'conduct of a sexual nature.'"

Dominguez has denied the allegations. He said in a statement after Wagenknecht's office announced last Wednesday that there was "no actionable finding" against him that he wants to move on to debating voter issues about schools.

"From the beginning, I have made it clear that any allegation should be taken with the utmost sincerity, care, due process and accountability," he wrote. "And with this process completed, I will continue this campaign for

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Zelenskyy: No early warning on attack

Lack of intel sharing comes as Russia hits Ukraine power grid

By Samya Kullab and Barry Hatton
ASSOCIATED PRESS

KYIV, Ukraine — Russia launched new attacks on Ukraine's energy infrastructure using ballistic missiles and jet-powered drones, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Monday, adding that Kyiv again received no early warning of the attack from partner countries that previously shared their intelligence.

Zelenskyy is grappling with recent Washington moves benefiting Russian President Vladimir Putin, including waiving U.S. sanctions on Moscow and signing a deal to buy Russian diesel.

Moscow and Kyiv, meanwhile, were discussing the possible evacuation of the Russian-occupied frontline city of Oleshky in the southern Kherson region, where about 2,000 people have been cut off from food and medical supplies for months, according to a Ukrainian human rights official.

Zelenskyy said speed restrictions are still in place on Kyiv's use of the military-grade version of U.S. company SpaceX's satellite internet service.

Full service was being restored at the end of last week, but Zelenskyy said Monday that the restrictions are still slowing Ukraine's drones along the front.

Also, a severe shortage of U.S.-made Patriot air defense systems has made Ukraine more vulnerable. Delays are still occurring with some "vital supplies" from the U.S., Zelenskyy said without elaborating, and senior Kyiv officials are urgently contacting other countries to strengthen air defenses.

Western intelligence sharing has helped Ukraine counter Russia's devastating ballistic missiles and hold back Moscow's full-scale invasion, which began more than 4 ½ years ago.

President Donald Trump says Washington hasn't stopped providing intelligence to Kyiv. Secretary of State Marco Rubio repeated that position Monday.

The Russian nighttime barrage

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Mayoral candidate Willie Wilson, center, submits his nominating petitions to the Chicago Board of Elections on Monday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/TRIBUNE**

ELECTION 2027 CHICAGO MAYOR

Delivery of signatures kicks off mayoral race

Five candidates show up on first day to haul petitions to Board of Elections site

By Alice Yin and Jake Sheridan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Mayoral contenders began pouring into the Chicago Board of Elections Loop Super Site bright and early Monday, hoping to become the next occupant of City Hall's fifth floor with the help of their stacks of petition signatures, even taller campaign promises and a little bit of luck.

Five candidates showed up on the first day to turn in petitions, earning them a draw in the lottery for the first spot on the February ballot. In order of arrival, they were businessman Willie Wilson, lobbyist John Kelly, U.S. Rep. Mike Quigley, Chicago Housing Authority Commissioner Matt Brewer and Illinois Secretary of State Alexi Giannoulias.

Missing was Mayor Brandon Johnson, whose team said he was focused on his fourth budget address that's scheduled for Wednesday morning.

By skipping the early fanfare, the incumbent stayed above the political fray. Like his predecessor, Lori Lightfoot, he will likely wait until the final day for petitions next week, which affords candidates a lottery entry for the last spot on the ballot.

Illinois Comptroller Susana Mendoza and attorney William Quinlan will also wait until next Monday to file, their mayoral campaigns said.

Monday's mayoral contenders jammed into a long line that snaked through a dim lobby outside the election office, bumping elbows and shaking hands with aldermanic hopefuls from across Chicago who were also turning in sheets of names they collected to get on the ballot.

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Shoplifter prison admissions up in Cook County

Spike comes amid Burke policy change, 'outdated' state law

By Madeline Buckley
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Earlier this month, a man walked into a West Side grocery store, according to a police report, and tried to walk out of the shop with two concealed cans of an alcoholic beverage.

Even though the cost of the alleged theft was around $13, the 29-year-old man, who the report notes is a U.S. veteran, is facing a felony retail theft charge due to a criminal background that includes a retail theft conviction and a stint in prison for armed robbery.

"Do not go back to that Food for Less," Cook County Judge Luciano Panici Jr. warned as he set conditions for his release from jail from a courtroom at the Leighton Criminal Court Building. "They do not want your business."

This man's case is only just beginning, but Cook County prison admission data suggests that if convicted, his $13 shoplifting incident is more likely to land him in prison than any other point in recent years.

In Cook County, felony case filings and prison admissions for retail theft have risen sharply since 2024, according to data reviewed

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Cook County State's Attorney Eileen O'Neill Burke speaks to the media at the Leighton Criminal Court Building on Dec. 16, 2025. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

5 dead in apparent murder-suicide

Five people were found shot to death in Mundelein in what police on Monday called an apparent murder-suicide. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Bulls, NBA adjust to anti-tanking rules

For the Bulls this season, it's hard to tell how a commitment to a rebuild will translate to their record, as new rules no longer incentivize dismal results. **Sports**

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